LOCAL PLANNING AREAS PARTNERSHIPS

May 2025
Volume 2, Issue 5

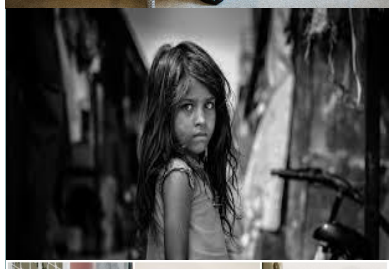
Tips & Tidbits Newsletter

OVERCOMING THE SILENCE OF GENERATIONAL POVERTY

*This story is taken from **"Invisible Literacies"** Donna M. Beegle*
Oct. 2003—Nov. 2003

Donna Beegle shares "I was born into a family where no one was educated beyond the eight grade. For generations, my family subsisted on menial-wage employment and migrant work." Although we worked hard, we were constantly evicted, hungry, and struggling with poverty. Early on, I learned that education meant stress: the stress of trying to arrive on time; having the right clothing, shoes, and lunch; and completing homework projects. Like others born into generational poverty, I find that thinking of my early educational experiences evokes memories of violence, humiliation, and fear; school became peripheral to my family life and earning a living.

By age 15, I had dropped out of school,, married, and worked in a foam rubber factory, as a migrant laborer, and in other menial jobs. At 25, I had two children and was divorced and homeless. At that time, I was fortunate to learn of a pilot program connect to a community college, the goal of which was to help single women gain education or skills to earn a living. I earned by GED, a proud moment for my family and me, I was encouraged and sought a higher degree, To my despair, I found that if I went to college, the state would sanction me and severely cut my welfare check (a policy still in effect in all but five states today).



I was determined to go to college, and was finally able to do so when I secured subsidized housing. With support from the program staff and my family, I entered a community college, but my fear, humiliation, and insecurity emerged once again when professors wrote comments such as "fragment," "double negative," and "run on" on my papers. My language created difficulties. I said ain't and confused gone with went, and seen with saw. I sensed that I was being judged as unintelligent by those around me.

Professors rarely asked for my opinions or thoughts. Dr. Fulford was an exception. He worked with me to help me move from non-standard English to middle-class language. Another source of support was my brother, who after reading widely during twelve years in prison, helped me through my studies by sending me extensive letters about the content of my courses. I continued my graduate education with Dr. Fulford, and worked for five years to increase the graduation rates at the high school I had attended.

(Cont. on next page)

Ultimately, I attained a Ph.D. My personal experiences, my determination to earn an advanced degree, and my work with those in generational poverty let me to the research that is the subject of this paper.

In this article I present some of the findings from a study I conducted of people who grew up in generational poverty but have achieved success through education (Beegle, 2000). The larger study was guided by these two questions:

GENERATIONAL POVERTY

[1.] What are the institutional, environmental, and personal experiences of students from the third generation of poverty who have completed bachelor's degrees?

[2.] What strategies and experiences contributed to their success?

Poverty in the U.S.

Today, as in the past, education continues to be held up as the best escape route from a life of poverty (Gans, 1995; Holleb, 1972; Levine & Nidiffer, 1996; Mortenson, 1998; Myrdal, 1962). Many of those who rise to middle-class standing in the United Stated do so primarily by obtaining a college education (Higginbotham & Weber, 1992). Paradoxically, people struggling with poverty are the least likely to become literate and achieve a college education (Mortenson, 1998; U.S. Department of Commerce, 1999). With poverty and illiteracy continuing to be passed down this way, there s a great need to understand how to increase literacy rates and educational success for students from generational poverty backgrounds.

"Although there has been some progress made in diminishing the educational barriers of race, gender, geography, and religion, poverty is the one barrier that has not been even partially overcome".

MEET DR. BEEGLE

Dr. Donna M. Beegle inspires and educates individual, organizations, politicians and entire communities with proven models to better outcomes for people in poverty.

Born into a migrant labor family and married at 15, Dr. Beegle is the only member of her family who has not been incarcerated, By age 24, she earned her GED and then, within 10 years, received her doctorate in Educational Leadership. She is an authentic voice from poverty, who speaks, writes and trains across the nation to break the iron cage of poverty for others through services provided by her company, Communications Across Barriers (CAB). Dr. Beegle's inspiring story of moving from 28 years of homelessness to achieving a doctorate and her groundbreaking work assisting people to move out of poverty have been featured in newspapers and television around the nation, including CNN and PBS.

Poverty and Literacy with Dr. Donna M. Beegle

Although some progress has been made in diminishing the educational barriers of race, gender, geography, and religion (Mortenson 1993), poverty is the one barrier that has not been even partially overcome. In 1970, a person from the lowest income quartile was only 16% as likely to complete a bachelor's degree as a person from the highest income quartile. By 1989, the rate had fallen to 11% (Mortenson, 1991), and in 1996, to 10% (Levine & Nidiffer, 1996; Mortenson, 1996). Since then, an even lower percentage of the poorest people in the U.S. have become educated (Valdez, 1998; Greenberg, Trawn, & Pimpton, 1999).

In the literature, there is a little distinction made between working-class poverty, temporary poverty, situational poverty, and generational poverty. This lack of contextual clarity perpetuates the lack of understanding of the realities experienced by students living in generational poverty. For that reason, my research respondents were all college graduates whose families had lived in poverty for at least three generations.

Context of the Study

All of the people in this study grew up in generational poverty and graduated from college or university. Primary participants, ranging in age from 22-60, included 6 while males, 11 white females, 2 Hispanic males 2 African American males, 2 Hispanic females and 1 Asian female. First, I conducted intensive 2 1/2 hour interviews with four focus groups comprised of 24 college graduates who grew up in generational poverty. Second, I administered a questionnaire that was given to the 24 focus-study members and an additional 32 college graduates with similar backgrounds. The questionnaire had a three-fold purpose: [1.] to elicit background information on environmental and personal factors likely to have influenced a student's ability to complete a bachelor's degree, [2.] to assist in shaping the development of the focus-group guidebook by gathering descriptive data and a profile of students experiences in achieving their degrees, and [3.] to create a pool from which to select focus-group participants. The primary benefit of the questionnaire was the collection of background data. This provided a focus for group interviews and supported the main objective of this study, which is to identify common strategies used by student from generational poverty to overcome poverty barriers and complete a bachelor's degree.

Picture credit: United Way of Greensboro

INVISIBLE LITERACIES (CONT)

Tape recordings, field notes, a reflection journal, and notes from a trained observer informed by analysis of the data. When reporting percentages of quantitative date, I use the term respondent to refer to everyone who answered the questionnaire and participants to refer to those who were a part of the focus group.

Findings

Several finding emerged from the data. In general, participants articulated that they experienced great shame and humiliation growing up on poverty. They believed that outsiders perceived poverty to be their fault. Participants faced physical, emotional, sociological, and economic barriers to literacy and education at all states of their lives. Of particular note were participants' discussions about appearance; jobs; basic needs, including housing, food, and health care; money and control over ones; life. I briefly report on each of these categories below.

Appearance

Participants descried a world in which appearance was important and one of the elements by which they were judged, a factor in their hate for and alienation from school. Many respondents related experiences in which they were humiliated or embarrassed by their poverty or felt embarrassed by the appearance of parent or family members. Stories about appearance frequently focused on cleanliness, hairstyles, clothing, and shoes. Julie stated "Everyone could tell I was poor by my ragged clothes, horrible shoes, and free lunch tickets." Another respondent, Kimberly, said that "no one wanted us around" because "our hair was dirty and stringy and most people made us feel like we didn't belong." Such storis make participants aware that their and their parents' appearances were not considered normal.

Expectations for Jobs

Respondents reported that their expectations for jobs were shaped by their parents and o9ther around them. When asked, "As a child, what did you want to be when you grew up?", 87% of the respondents did not have job or career goals. Most reported that they never thought about "being something." "I just wanted to survive and grow up, " said Larry. "I never considered myself to be worthy to be anything." Of the females who identified a future goal, 72% stated that they wanted to be mother when they grew up. Six males also identified parenting as their future goal. When asked how they would earn a living, 85% of the respondents reported that they would find "some kind" of wok. Parents of 69% of the respondents survived on welfare, disability pay , or migrant work.

Participants talked about jobs as a abstract concepts. They did not have a specific idea about what a job for them would be. As children, respondents envisioned three categories of jobs, all of which were familiar and visible: jobs they had seen performed in their communities, such as police officer, hair cutter, clerk, office worker, food server, and truck driver; jobs that were held by people they knew, such as working in manufacturing, textiles, fishing, a glass factory, a cannery, sign painting, and seasonal migrant work; and jobs they had seen enacted or portrayed on television, such as Solid Gold dancer, ballet dancer, nurse, and doctor. 71% of the participants also reported that their personal worth was judged by the kind of work their parents did or did not do.

HELPFUL READING

Popular books

Demon Copperhead written by Barbara Kingsolver

Poverty by America written by Matthew Desmond

Not a Crime to Be Poor written by Peter Edelman

Educational book

The End of Poverty: How We Can Make It Happen In our Lifetime written by Jeffrey D Sachs

See Poverty... Be the Difference written by Donna Beegle

Elementary student reading

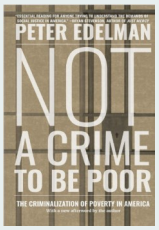
On our Street—Our first talk about poverty written by Jillian Roberts

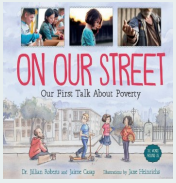
Those Shoes—written by Maribeth Boelts

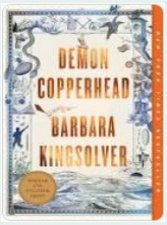
Others

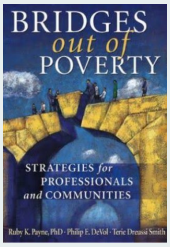
Poor Kids in a Rich Country, written by Lee Rainwater and Timothy Smeeding

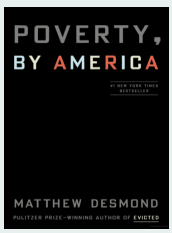
If Beale Street Could Talk, written by James Baldwin

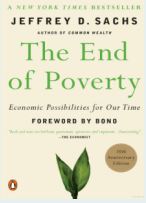












TWO DISTINCT COMMUNICATION STYLES

BETWEEN ORAL & PRINT

- Two distinct styles of Communicating & learning : oral and print
- These two communication styles come from their respective cultural and contextual roots:
  - Oral Culture
  - Print Culture

Learning middle-class language and communication styles proved to be essential for success in the education world. Participants learned middle-class norms by observing and interacting in meaningful ways with middle-class people. These interactions provided them with cultural artifacts and helped them understand the norms and the language. That dominate education. They also reported learning to imitate the social behavior of the middle-class. In a fuller version of this study, I found that adjusting to the education culture was particularly important to breaking the cycle of generational poverty (Beegle 2000). The behavior norms of people from poverty where not rewarded in the education setting. Grammar and vocabulary emerged as barriers to literacy and education for students.

Ong (1982) found that most people who live in poverty exhibit characteristics of oral culture, getting most of the their information verbally. Ong characterized oral culture as relationship-based, spontaneous, and strongly associated with emotions and physical touch. Verbal communication may not necessarily focus on one idea, but many bounce from idea to idea. Ong found that people who get their information primarily from reading exhibit characteristics of print culture, and tend to be linear, analytical, individualistic, and focused.

When students from poverty backgrounds enter the world of education, their communication styles are likely to clash with formal nature of print-culture communication.

"Asking a single mother with a sixth-grade education and three children to spend an hour reading or helping with homework is unrealistic."

Conclusion by Donna Beegle, herself.

My personal experiences of growing up in generational poverty and the voices of research participants can contribute to our understanding of what is necessary for increasing literacy rates for students from this background. To assume the challenging task of becoming literate and educated, these students must bridge social-call, cultural, and academic gaps. Listening to the voices of those experiencing generational poverty forces us to confront the inadequate ways in which we, as a society and in educational settings,, deal with social-class differences. The extremely low numbers of people in generational poverty who achieve literacy and obtain college degrees force us to examine the limited progress we have made with educational equity in this area. The information, stories, and recommendations for respondent in this study can help us do something about it. My education, my work and my passion are to help people from all races who are trapped in generational poverty are heard and their perspectives understood.